Gem

How to Craft an Email Sequence for Recruiting Outreach

Best Practices and Examples for a 4-Stage Sequence

In recruitment—as in so much of life—persistence pays. The old adage is perhaps especially true when it comes to recruiting passive talent. After all, it's no small feat to prompt engagement (let alone action) in talent that's already satisfied where they are. Passive talent is busy with their full-time jobs. They're likely spending more time in their work email than in their personal email throughout the day. They may only have small windows of time in which to sit with the contents of an outreach message and the idea of a career change. Add to this the inertia of career contentment, and you've got your work cut out for you if you hope to ever hear back from them.

Which is why it's surprising that so many recruiters still take a one-and-done approach to cold email outreach. Studies have shown that it can take between 12 and 20 touchpoints to influence a career decision. Our own data at Gem—taken from over one million prospect outreach campaigns—shows that a single email receives, on average, a 13% reply rate, while a 4-email sequence receives a 32% reply rate. In other words, following up means *more-than-doubling* (2.5x-ing, in fact) your chances of receiving an interested response from a prospective candidate. The cardinal sin in sourcing is to send a single email, letting all the work you've done to research, source, and craft a strong message fora handful of candidates go down the drain after that. Why not try to maximize your response rates after all that time and effort?

Naturally, this begs the question of what a follow-up "looks like": what should those additional emails *say*? You likely have your template for that first email down. Ideally your *initial* outreach email should do four things.

An effective first outreach email contains most, if not all, of the following elements:

Tell them how you found them, proving you did your homework.

Why are you reaching out to *them*, specifically? How does your open role align with their experience or career goals? How does your company align with their interests or values?

Tell them what your company does and what role you're looking to fill—*briefly*.

How does the open role support the company's mission? Identify 2-3 details that would appeal to their interests. Mention impact.

Mention a facet (or two) of your employee value proposition.

Your EVP is the unique set of benefits employees receive in return for the experience, skills, and other contributions they bring to your company. What distinguishes you from the perspective of employee experience?

Offer a call to action.

Your goal with initial outreach is to get prospective candidates on the phone so you can have the real dialogue there. Be specific about next steps.

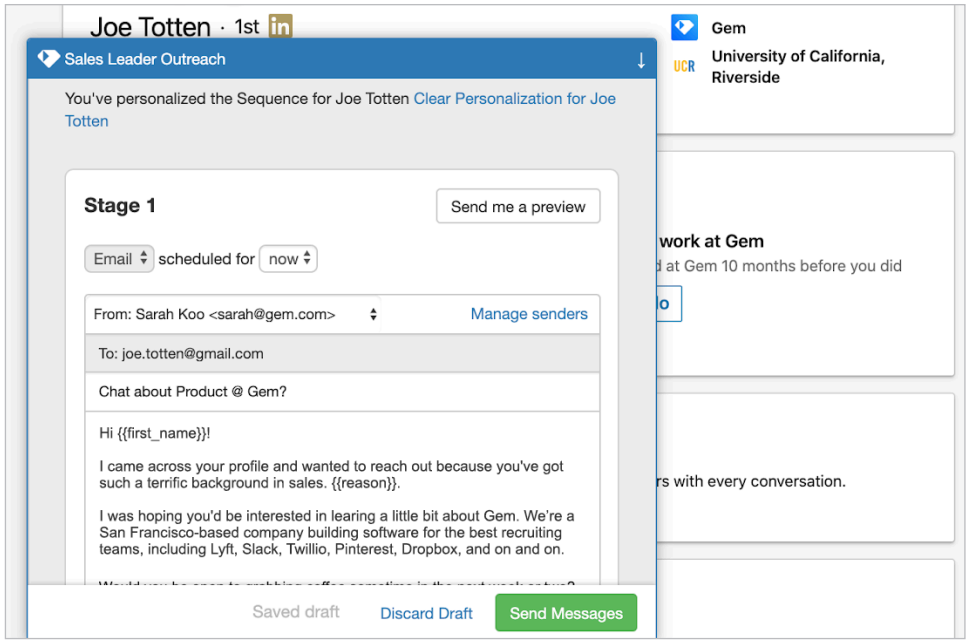
But your follow-ups will demand different strategies—and maybe even a little agility as you track engagement with them.

Effective follow-ups emphasize elements of your employee value proposition that you didn't mention in your initial outreach. They'll add new value by shining a light on *other* facets of the company. They may be "sent from" other members of your organization—the hiring manager, a C-level, or even another person on the team—so it looks like there's a *community* of employees who are excited about them. Collectively, the emails in your outreach sequence should be understood as the unfolding of a narrative about your company, its open role, and your prospective candidates' place in that story.

Of course, it's possible to do all of this while personalizing your messaging at scale. The following examples are "templates"; and you can see where whole paragraphs can be used when sending in batch to save time. Indeed, the examples below aren't personalized *so much* as they are detailed in their illustration of EVPs, thoughtful about whom to send as (executives, referrers, hiring managers), and tactful in the content that's included as links and quotes.

But each example is *also* fine-tuned to meet the prospect as an individual. At Gem, we offer {{reason}} and {{extra}} tokens that allow recruiters to easily customize outreach—something we especially recommend doing for harder-to-fill roles. After all, the less generic-sounding your messaging is the more likely you are to drive engagement. So even if you don't have the time to thoroughly personalize *every* email you send, you can author a few very strong and effective sentences that get dropped into top prospects' messages, increasing the likelihood you'll hear back from them.

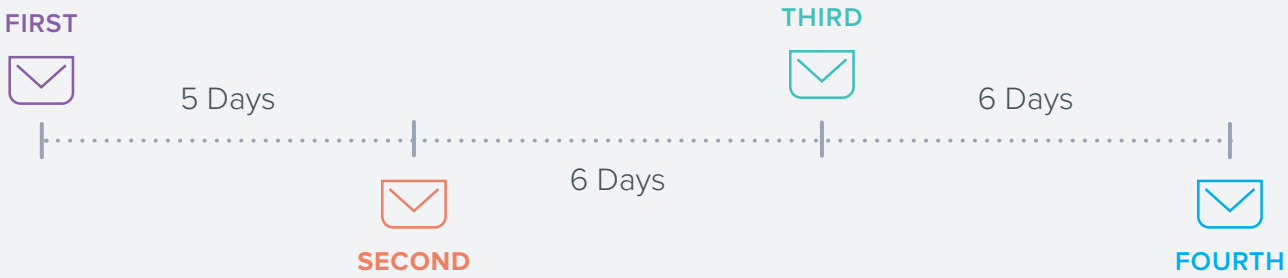
Below are three examples of 4-stage outreach sequences that employ a variety of strategies to pique prospective candidate interest and prompt engagement. We hope these help you imagine the kind of ongoing story you could tell passive talent about your own open roles, their respective teams, alignment, and your organization.



Tokens in Gem are either auto-captured from the prospect's LinkedIn profile (i.e. {{company}}) or manually entered by a sourcer (i.e. {{reason}}). These variables can be dropped anywhere in subject lines or message copy when crafting a sequence. The value will automatically populate the email, replacing the token when the outreach is sent. Tokens offer the best of both worlds: personalization and automation.

Consider Your Cadence

Along with conversational cadence (the rate at which you move your messaging forward), consider send cadence (delivery timing). The timeline shows a common message cadence we see with our customers.



Example 1

Subject: Looking for our next Haskell Expert in Chicago

Stage 1

Hi, Javier!

My name is Chris and I'm working alongside our CTO, Erika, at XYZ Financial to find some of the best back-end engineers to grow our current team. I've just spent the last hour on your GitHub and LinkedIn profiles, and called Erika over to show her the most recent debugging feature you published on GitHub. Needless to say, Erika's thrilled. We're actually working on a similar project—and in Haskell, which it looks like you're currently programming in!

XYZ Financial is an account aggregation technology looking to make big waves in fintech. Last year we opened our second engineering hub in Chicago, raised $47M in funding, and we're on track to double in size by next year. Our next few hires will be critical, as they'll shape the engineering culture of our new office.

What it's like to work on the eng team:

- No product managers. You'll own and drive the product from start to finish
- Tons of growth opportunity as we expand from a team of 6 to 20+ by the end of the year
- Write meaningful code that supports our users in experiencing financial freedom
- Flexible environment (most of our team works from home at least once a week)
- Tackle technical challenges across internal tooling, guest experience, authentication, and data

Do you have time to jump on a call this week? I'd love to hear more about your background, your current projects, and your career aspirations... and of course, tell you more about our company.

I look forward to talking to you,

Chris Haskins
Recruiting Manager, XYZ Financial
LinkedIn

Here's what the opening of this outreach message would look like in Gem:

Hi, {{first_name}}!

My name is Chris and I'm working alongside our CTO, Erika, at XYZ Financial to find some of the best back-end engineers to grow our current team. {{reason}}.

The remainder of the message is a template. Note that Chris inserted three sentences, using the {{reason}} token, specific to Javier. He can fill in the {{reason}} token for talent he's particularly excited about (or not fill it in at all), and the message will send seamlessly to every prospective candidate in that project.

What this initial outreach does well:

It uses flattery to great effect.

There's a kind of double ego-stroking happening here: Javier's work was terrific enough that it was worth digging into; and what came up was worth sharing with the CTO. You'll also note the flattery in the subject line ("expert"). Studies have shown that even overtly manipulative flattery is remarkably effective, by the way. That's because compliments trigger reward centers in the brain. Subject lines that appeal to the ego ("Are you our next top-tier data scientist?") will leave recipients wanting more of the resulting "mini-high," prompting them to click in.

It brings in the CTO.

Including the hiring manager, the CEO, or whomever the role reports to is a great strategy. When the prospect thinks there's more than one person who has a vested interest in them, and that you're working together to get their attention, they're all the more likely to respond.

It uncovers areas of overlap.

Chris explains exactly what caught his attention about Javier. In this case—as will often be the case—it was commonalities (similar projects, same code). Prospects want to know why you're reaching out to *them*. Whether it's shared values, complementary skill sets, or past projects in alignment with your own, let them know why you think they're a good match for the position. ("We're hiring and I think you'd make a great fit" may sound too generic to be effective.)

It gives a glimpse of what it's like to work at the company.

According to LinkedIn, the biggest roadblock candidates face when changing jobs is "not knowing what it's really like to work at the company." This email makes a great first attempt at offering a glimpse. We suggest 3-5 details (bullet-pointed for easier reading) that will appeal to your prospect's interests. Your follow-ups can add more color to the picture you paint in that first message.

Stage 2

Hi, Javier!

It's Chris again. I just wanted to follow up on my email from last week and see if you've thought about hopping on a call so I can hear about what you're looking for in your next role.

I also wanted to send on a blog post from one of our founding engineers, Devin Ramirez, who recently wrote about the philosophy of product engineering that we hold here. Devin wrote:

"One of the most exciting things about my job at XYZ Financial is that Product Engineers own features (or products) from end-to-end—from the database to the interface and from initial idea to successful launch. We're individually trusted to build what makes good product- and business-sense, we'll wear any number of hats as needed, and we work one-on-one with customers to ensure we're iterating toward the best solution. For us, that means actually jumping on the phone with customers; and this way of doing things has kept us uniquely responsive to customer needs."

Devin mentioned she'd be more than happy to chat with you if you'd like to hear from someone on the team before hopping on a call with me. She's free this Thursday; would that work for you?

Looking forward to hearing from you, Javier!

Chris Haskins
Recruiting Manager, XYZ Financial
LinkedIn

What this follow-up does well:

In letting an employee speak *for* him, Chris offers "social proof" that confirms—from an employee's own mouth—that the role is as great as Chris claimed it was in his initial outreach. (In using an excerpt from the blog post, Chris also made it easier on himself when it came to crafting the email.)

Talent is hungry for employee perspectives; so if you have those in the form of videos, quotes, or blog posts, send them out. Offering to set passive talent up on calls with prospective team members is also a great strategy—just make sure you and those employees are on the same page when it comes to the kind of time commitment this might require of them. Maybe you only offer it as an option to the talent you *most* want to come work for you.

Stage 3

Hi, Javier,

My name is Erika Kinsey, and I'm the CTO at XYZ Financial. Chris told me he's reached out to you a few times over the last week about open eng roles in our new Chicago office. I thought I'd try you myself, since I'm as excited as Chris is about the kind of experience you could bring to the table here.

Our backend team builds the underlying services, infrastructure, and APIs that power our products. Right now they're re-architecting some of that, and I'd love to tell you where I think you could contribute to that project and what challenges I think you could help us solve. I'd also love to hear what you're working on these days—I have a feeling your interests overlap with our initiatives quite a bit!

How's Tuesday for you?

Erika

Erika Kinsey (she/her)
CTO, XYZ Financial
BackendToTheFront.com

What this follow-up does well:

Erika's email (whether or not she "wrote" it) is flattering. An email direct from the CTO is likely to get more attention than one from a recruiter. In part this is because of perceived influence; in part it's because talent knows that outreach isn't part of the daily activities of most managers. When a hiring manager or executive reaches out, it's because they saw value in that outreach—*not* because they needed to fill a quota. Talent will respond in kind.

Knowledge-workers want their work to be challenging and to have meaning. They want to contribute to solutions. Erika leverages that inclination by mentioning the "challenges I think you could help us solve." That's likely to spark curiosity and the instinct for inquiry great talent has. Finally, she's specific about next steps: prospects who are interested will respond before Tuesday with the time they're free.

Stage 4

Hi, Javier,

Just checking in one last time. It sounds like you and Erika didn't get a chance to connect last week. My guess at this point is that things are going great for you at {{company}}, and this just isn't the time to engage in a conversation about the next phase of your career.

I don't want to keep hounding if the timing isn't right. That said, I know how quickly that horizon can change—so I'll check back in six months or so and see where you're at. (It'll be interesting to see what our Chicago office looks like at that point!)

In the meantime, feel free to keep up with our engineering blog, where the team will be posting updates about their projects, our products, and their growth. And if you've got any engineers in your network who are looking to join an account aggregation software company that's growing more quickly than any other in the industry, send them my way! I have a philosophy that good people know good people; and so I'm happy to talk to anyone you know.

Best,

Chris Haskins
Recruiting Manager, XYZ Financial
LinkedIn

What this "break-up email" does well:

Your breakup email may be the hook that finally gets talent's attention. (Gem's data shows that 23% of the replies sourcers see are from those final "hail Mary" attempts to reach out.) That's because the breakup email does something different than your other emails do: it appeals to loss aversion. It shifts the dynamic and turns the tables. Start ignoring us, and *now* we want your attention. Confirm *for us* that we're not moving forward in the process, and we want to take control of the narrative again.

Chris knows this. He's asked prospects who didn't respond to imagine growth in the Chicago office without them. ("It'll be interesting to see what the Chicago office looks like at that point!") He offers a resource (the EPD blog) as a way for talent to keep up on the team's projects and successes—and perhaps as a way to experience FOMO. And he continues to flatter Javier ("I have a philosophy that good people know good people"), leaving the door open for conversations in the future.

Example 2

Subject: What's Your Next Career Move, Brian?

Stage 1

Hi there Brian,

My name is Kelly Arnone and I'm the CEO at X App. I discovered your profile on LinkedIn this week while looking for a Sales Ops Manager for our fast-growing sales team. It led me to both of your articles on sales team leadership on Medium. I'm really impressed by the thought and consideration you've put into running your teams.

If you're getting a lot of emails about career opportunities these days—and you probably are—I imagine you're not hearing much from CEOs directly. But I attribute the success we've seen so far at X App in part to my dedication to finding the best talent, putting them in the same room, and watching them thrive. That's why I commit so much of my own personal time to sourcing and outreach.

I'd love to tell you about our plan to open up a new market this year and about how we see experimentation and autonomy as central to a world-class sales team. If that sounds interesting to you, feel free to schedule a 30-minute intro call with someone on our TA team here. And if we discover it's a ring you'd like to throw your hat into, I'd love to grab a coffee with you.

I look forward to getting to talk to you soon, Brian,

Kelly Arnone
CEO, X App
LinkedIn

Here's what the opening of this outreach message would look like in Gem:

Hi there {{first_name}},

My name is Kelly Arnone and I'm the CEO at X App. I discovered your profile on LinkedIn this week while looking for a Sales Ops Manager for our fast-growing sales team. {{reason}}.

The remainder of the message is a template.

What this initial outreach does well:

It asks a question.

The subject line understands psychology. Asking questions allows the conversation to begin even before the prospect hits "Reply." *Happy in your current role? What's one thing you'd change about your job? Ready to love coming to work every day?* These all place prospects in an instant dialogue with your outreach, making them curious about what *your* answer to the question is. It also slows them down. After all, these might be questions they never thought to ask themselves.

It's from the CEO.

Again, whether or not the CEO actually *wrote* this doesn't matter; the point is that someone who *doesn't* have a quota to fill appears to be reaching out. Of course, if you use this send-on-behalf-of (SOBO) strategy, make sure you have permission to use the sender's name. With Gem, there are two ways for recruiters to SOBO hiring managers, C-levels, or anyone else in the company. They can create an alias and set up email forwarding (in which case, replies go to the recruiter), or they can request "Send From" access (in which case, replies go directly to the HM, who then takes charge of the correspondence, but the recruiter is notified).

It's short and to-the-point.

Granted, there's often enough power in outreach from top-level management that the message *can* be shorter; but that doesn't mean outreach from talent acquisition can't *also* be concise. Remember: The prospect hasn't displayed any interest yet; so there's no reason to overwhelm them with details. A little praise, one or two facts about the position or the company, and you've said all you need to say for an initial gauge of interest. This message passes the "single-screen view" test on mobile. You may want to account for the fact that that's the screen size recipients may be looking at.

There's a clear call to action.

Our previous examples contain clear calls to action as well; but they'd require some back-and-forth before a time got scheduled. Here, the prospect can schedule a time in just a few clicks. There's no question of what happens next, and no waiting on a response before something gets locked into a calendar.

Stage 2

Hi, Brian!

My name is Geoff and I'm following up on Kelly's message from last week. As she mentioned, we're on the lookout for a world-class Sales Ops Manager at X App. She sent me your name this week after she reached out to you because she thinks you'd be a great fit for us. We're not a well-known company (yet!); but we're worth watching out for. We just closed our Series B ($18 million); and we've seen 100% YOY growth so far. For the next year, we're focusing our business strategy almost entirely on opening up a new market. We've got some ambitious goals and a fantastic team ready to chase them.

Here are a few more links about our company and what we're up to:

- A day in the life of the Sales team at X App
- Sales values and principles (We're working on clarifying these for ourselves; so feel free to ask questions/offer input. My personal favorite is "discerning experimentation.")
- A blog post by our Director of Sales, Jasmin, about diversity at X App
- Our matching gifts page (We match employee donations to local nonprofits and keep a public running tab on where that money has gone)

I imagine it's a busy time for you at {{company}}, but I'd love to hop on a quick call with you and tell you more about us. I'll save us some back-and-forth and give you a call at 12:30 this Thursday—but if that time doesn't work for you, send me another that works, and I'll be sure to reach out.

Thanks, Brian. Looking forward to chatting!

Geoff Waller (pronouns: he/his)
Sales Recruiting Lead, X App

What this follow-up does well:

Geoff touches on a-day-in-the-life, diversity, and team- and company-wide values—all through links, without crowding the message. Brian can click on these as he's interested... and if Geoff is using the right platform, he can discern what kind of content Brian is interested in based on what links he clicks into.

All of these things fall under X App's employee value proposition. Whether it's a flexible work schedule, education reimbursement, intellectual stimulation, personal development opportunities, or company culture, the EVP answers the question—from the prospect's point of view—*What's in it for me?* Asking yourself *"so what?"* at the end of every sentence will help you know what to cut and what to keep. If the benefit isn't self-evident, make it so.

Geoff has also simplified his CTA to a no-word response: "I'll save us some back-and-forth and give you a call at 12:30 this Thursday." Unless Brian says otherwise, he knows that phone call is coming—and he'll be ready to pick up if his interest is piqued. Mental energy expended on Brian's part? Next to nothing.

Stage 3

Hi again, Brian,

Just circling back to see if you'd be interested in a role enabling our fast-growing team.

I also thought you might want to check out our Culture Page, where you'll find everything from our demographic stats to our best-in-class benefits. One of my favorite benefits is that, on top of our generous vacation policy, X Appers are given one day a month off to work on their own passion projects or take a self-care day. Last month, our VP of Sales, Amanda, spent her day at the MoMA with her 12-year-old daughter, Kyle. Afterwards, she wrote a really interesting reflection on depth, perspective, and the sales funnel that I thought you'd appreciate. You can find it here.

I'd love to hear how you'd spend those days off! Let's discuss?

Hope to talk soon, Brian.

Geoff
Geoff Waller (pronouns: he/his)
Sales Recruiting Lead, X App

What this follow-up does well:

Because Geoff didn't overload Brian on X App's employee value proposition in the last email, he's got more to say in email #3 about the kinds of things the company offers its employees (terrific culture, self-care days). Brian gets "social proof" in the form of Amanda's blog post. What's more, Geoff has lowered the stakes of the conversation, which might make Brian more responsive. He's no longer asking to talk about the open role; rather, he's curious about how Brian would spend a day off—which is a way of asking about Brian's interests and hobbies outside of work. This is a low-commitment conversation; and this kind of question is worth experimenting with.

Stage 4

Hi Brian!

Well? The bad news is that Kelly and I haven't heard back from you. The *good* news is that this probably means you're loving your current role.

Since it seems the timing isn't right for us, this will be my last email. But I wanted to sign off with a gift written by a former colleague at my last company: an Ultimate Guide to Sales Ops. I imagine much of what's in here you already know; but Ravi has a take on sales territory assignment (see p. 14) that I think you might find interesting.

Wishing you the best, Brian. And of course, feel free to reach out if you'd ever like to chat in the future.

Geoff
Geoff Waller (pronouns: he/his)
Sales Recruiting Lead, X App

What this "break-up email" does well:

Geoff offers a parting gift, which is akin to saying "no hard feelings." It also keeps the door open for future conversations. *This* gift in particular shows that Geoff is deeply engaged in the kinds of roles he's recruiting for, and in understanding the nuances of the business he's supporting. From the perspective of a personal brand, this is a brilliant move. Brian is likely to remember this guide—and no matter *what* company Geoff is recruiting for in the future, if he hears from Geoff again, it will be outreach he receives with more warmth than annoyance.

Example 3

Subject: Your friend Nolan tells me you've got game

Stage 1

Terrence!

Happy Wednesday! My name is Carmen and I'm a recruiter at Range. We're expanding our design team right now, and I've been reaching out to my network to find the best of the best in Austin. I met up with Nolan for coffee last week and you came up as the most remarkable UX designer they know. I honestly can't imagine a more enthusiastic recommendation.

Would you be open to chatting this week about our open positions and why we've been named one of the Top 10 Startups to work for in Austin? My sense is you'd be a killer UX lead for us... but I also want to be clear that I'm not interested in "selling" you a job. Rather, I want to find out what your career goals are and what you'd be looking for in your next position. Of course, if your needs align with what we have to offer, we can go from there! If not, it will have been great to have met you.

Let me know when you're free this week, and I'll schedule a brief call for us.

Thanks, Terrence. I look forward to hearing from you!

Carmen Benisty (pronouns: she/her)
Range
Top 10 Startups to Work for in Austin
Range Scores $74M in Series C Financing Round

Here's what the opening of this outreach message would look like in Gem:

{{first_name}}!

Happy {{day_of_week}}! My name is Carmen and I'm a recruiter at Range. We're expanding our design team right now, and I've been reaching out to my network to find the best of the best in Austin. I met up with {{extra 1}} for coffee last week and you came up as the most remarkable UX designer they know. I honestly can't imagine a more enthusiastic recommendation.

The remainder of the message is a template.

What this initial outreach does well:

It mentions a referral.

When you've been referred to someone, call it out immediately—ideally in the subject line. Terrence is all the more likely to click in when he sees his friend's name there. After all, it's an instant endorsement; it piques curiosity; it gives you both a jumping-off point for conversation; and it minimizes the sense of risk associated with career change when talent already knows someone who works at your company.

It has personality.

Carmen's subject line ("you've got game") is bound to stand out in an inbox. Of course, you can take it further if you think the prospect would be open to it. Often you can get a sense of a prospect's sense of humor based on their social profiles. In this case, Carmen may have checked in with Nolan about the kind of approach Terrence would best respond to. Playfulness—in the form of puns, corny jokes, pop culture references, and more—offers an opportunity for real human connection.

It isn't pitching a job.

Remember, your primary goal in an initial reach-out is to schedule a meeting—nothing more. Carmen didn't bother giving Terrence any details about the position *because this message isn't about the job*; it's about learning more about Terrence. The lower the barrier, the better your chances of connecting. At *that* point, you can ascertain fit and alignment.

Carmen uses her pronouns.

This is a way of affirming allyship and showing that Range values diversity. 67% of active and passive talent say they take a company's workforce diversity into account when evaluating it. Being pronoun-forward in outreach is one of those small signals that can make an enormous difference.

It makes the most of the signature.

Carmen didn't say much about the company or the role in her message, but she left breadcrumbs for Terrence to follow if he wants to learn more. The great thing about this strategy is that, if you're using Gem, you can track which links are getting clicks—and which clicks prompt replies—to get a sense of what your most compelling content is.

Stage 2

Hi Terence,

It's Carmen again! Just circling back around to see if you have any interest in learning more about Range, our design team, how we're thinking about UX in our rebranding efforts... and what kinds of challenges and questions we'd love for you to help us answer.

If you're up for it, I can put you in touch with one of our former leads, Jaspreet. Jaspreet is still with us; but he's now our Head of Design. He led a team as big as the one you'd be leading if you were to join us; and he can give you much more insight on the day-to-day of the team than I could. Plus I think he'd be a great person to have in your network.

On the other hand, if you'd just like to hop on the phone with me for a quick 15-minute chat so I can tell you more about the role, that's great too! Even if you're not up for a career change just now, I think you'd be interested in what we're up to. I'm available tomorrow between 8 and 11 a.m. or Thursday 1 to 4 p.m. What would work for you?

I hope we get to chat, Terence. It would be great to get to know you.

Carmen Benisty (pronouns: she/her)
Range
Top 10 Startups to Work for in Austin
Range Scores $74M in Series C Fundraising Round

What this follow-up does well:

It's a brilliant move on Carmen's part to offer to put Terence in touch with an employee whose career path indicates what his *own* career path might look like if he were to join Range ("Jaspreet is still with us; but he's now our Head of Design"). Wherever you can highlight potential growth opportunities for prospective candidates, do so. Talent wants to know that they'd be taking on a role with an actual career path, and with opportunities for internal mobility, at your company.

Carmen also helps Terence imagine himself in the role at Range ("the team you'd be leading"); diffuses possible objections ("even if you're not up for a career change just now"); and generously offers to extend Terence's network (though Jaspreet), even if he ultimately isn't interested in the role.

Stage 3

Hey Terence!

Carmen tells me she's been trying to get ahold of you to chat about a UX role with us. I told her that her persistence was wise. :) I know it's been awhile; but I just wanted to put in a plug for Range. I've been here just less than a year now; but already the kind of impact I get to see my work have on the product has been amazing, and I've never enjoyed user testing and research more than I do with this product. Not to mention, you would absolutely love our team. (Here are some photos and videos of the design team's last offsite... I think a glass-blowing career is in my future, don't you?!)

I'd be so stoked to get to work with you again; and I'm happy to chat if you're on the fence about getting back to Carmen. But I think you should schedule some time with her—even if only to get a feel for what this role might be able to offer you.

Hope you're well, my friend... and hope to get to see you soon during your interview process!

Nolan Gold
Principal Designer
Range

What this follow-up does well:

It's one thing to have employees give you referrals; it's another for them to reach out *themselves* as part of your outreach sequence. As a friend and a former co-worker, Nolan serves as an instant endorsement for Range. He also minimizes the sense of risk Terrence might associate with career change. Even if you *don't* include referring employees in your actual sequence, it's a great strategy to have them reach out concurrently.

Stage 4

Hi Terence,

I thought I'd try you one last time (it's hard to let this one go given what I know about you and your design work)! Our design team's growth and our rebranding efforts are underway; and I just wanted to share with you some insights from the team and a sneak peek into some of the work we're doing on our website... if you're interested, check back at the beginning of next month; I think you'll be pleased by some of our design changes.

Growth at Range is showing no signs of slowing, and we'll be continuing to look for people to define our design roadmap for years to come; so I'll try you again in six months or so. Perhaps we'll be lucky, and you'll be ready for a new and exciting leadership position at that point?!

Of course, feel free to reach out any time between now and then. Nolan and I would love to hear from you.

All best,

Carmen Benisty (pronouns: she/her)
Range
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Range Scores $74M in Series C Financing Round

What this "break-up email" does well:

Long-term follow-up strategies like this achieve a few things at once. For one, it gives Terence the opportunity to reach out *now* if he's not willing to wait six months to hear from Carmen again. For another, it shows a balanced combination of continued interest and a willingness to take Terence's feelings into consideration, ultimately keeping future opportunities on the table. It also gives Terence plenty of time to consider the company in greater depth before Carmen reaches out again down the line.

Carmen pairs this with a few more breadcrumbs that might tip Terence toward responding: she links to some insights direct from the design team and to some of the designs in progress. Terence can see for *himself* what kind of work the team is doing. Plus, this access serves as a kind of trust-offering: it's unlikely that many external people have permission to see this work in progress.

How Gem Can Help

As capturing the attention of passive talent becomes the predominant strategy for talent acquisition teams—regardless of what the talent market looks like in any given moment—sourcers and recruiters are under pressure to refine and perfect their outreach strategies. Only the most timely and compelling emails will be opened, read, and replied to; and talent brand matters perhaps more than ever right now, as knowledge-workers are paying close attention to the companies that treat their candidates like people. This leaves TA teams with a lot of questions about outreach—from subject lines, to send times, to message copy—all while keeping the messaging real and genuine. At Gem, we've built our product on best practices to make your team all the more likely to see prospect engagement, and to initiate great candidate experiences.

Best Practices

4-Stage Email Sequences

90% of talent prefers to be contacted by email rather than InMail—which is great news for recruiters, since follow-ups can't be automated on LinkedIn. Gem's data shows that response rates increase as the number of emails in a sequence increases—from a 13% reply rate for 1 email, to a 32% reply rate for a 4-email sequence. After 4 emails, we start to see diminishing returns. A 4-stage initial sequence strikes the right balance between connecting with talent and preserving employer brand.

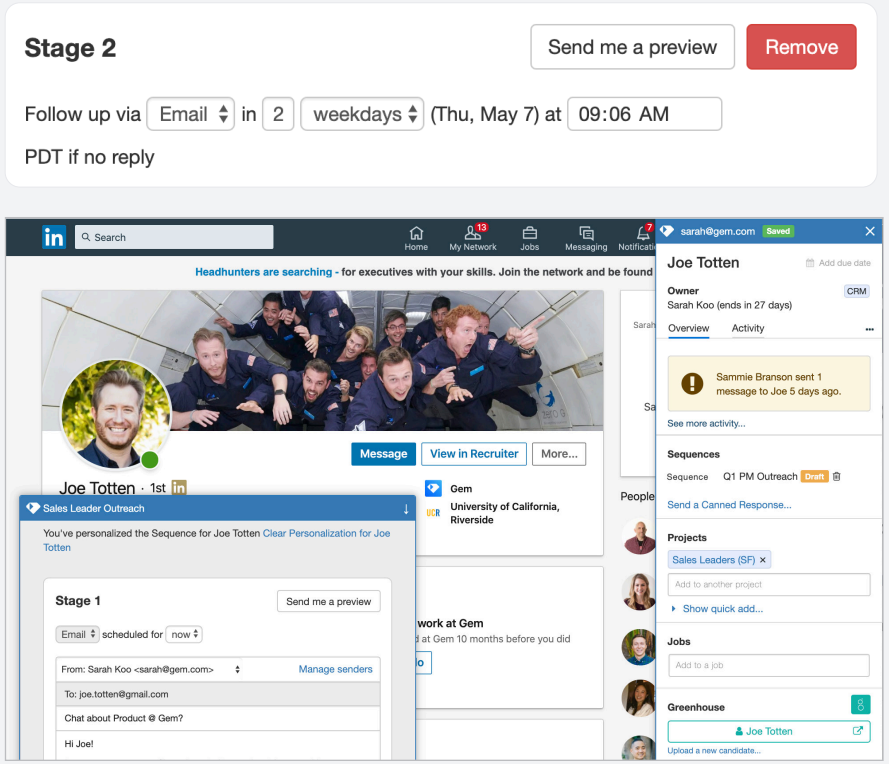
A 5-6-6 Sequence Cadence

5-6-6 (5 days between the first and second outreach, 6 days between second and third outreach, and another 6 days between third and fourth outreach) is the most common cadence we see with our users using a 4-stage message sequence. This cadence keeps your company top-of-mind for a few weeks, and ensures that each email is delivered on a different day of the week, increasing your chances you'll catch your prospect on a "down day."

How Gem Helps

Stages and Cadence: Automation

Gem's sequences are designed to put your outreach on autopilot using pre-scheduled stages. Each stage starts with a template, which auto-fills in personalized information from the prospect's LinkedIn profile. (Gem also finds prospects' email addresses, so you don't have to search for them.) You can schedule as many follow-ups in your sequence as you'd like, keeping best practices for cadence and send times in mind. Gem will automatically stop sending follow-ups as soon as a prospect replies to any stage in your sequence. When you source a new prospect on LinkedIn, you can queue up one of your sequences directly from the Gem Chrome extension, customize the content and message cadence for that particular prospect if you'd like, and schedule all your messages to fire off at the time you choose.



Best Practice

Personalize Your Subject Lines and Message Copy

Naturally, there's a direct correlation between subject lines and open rates. Personalized subject lines increase open rates by 26%—and as our data shows, they nearly double response rates. The same is true of personalized message copy: Gem's data shows that reply rates are 10-20% higher when the sender uses a {{reason}} token in the body copy.

How Gem Helps

Personalization: Tokens

Tokens represent values that are either auto-captured from the prospect's LinkedIn profile (i.e. "{{first_name}}") or manually input by the user (i.e. "{{reason}}"). The "{{reason}}" token is a Gem field that allows users to jot down the motivation for reaching out to a particular prospect *while* viewing a LinkedIn profile, and while it's still fresh in their minds. These variables can then be dropped anywhere in subject lines or message copy when creating a sequence. The value will automatically populate in the message, replacing the token when the outreach is sent. Tokens offer the best of both worlds: personalization and automation.

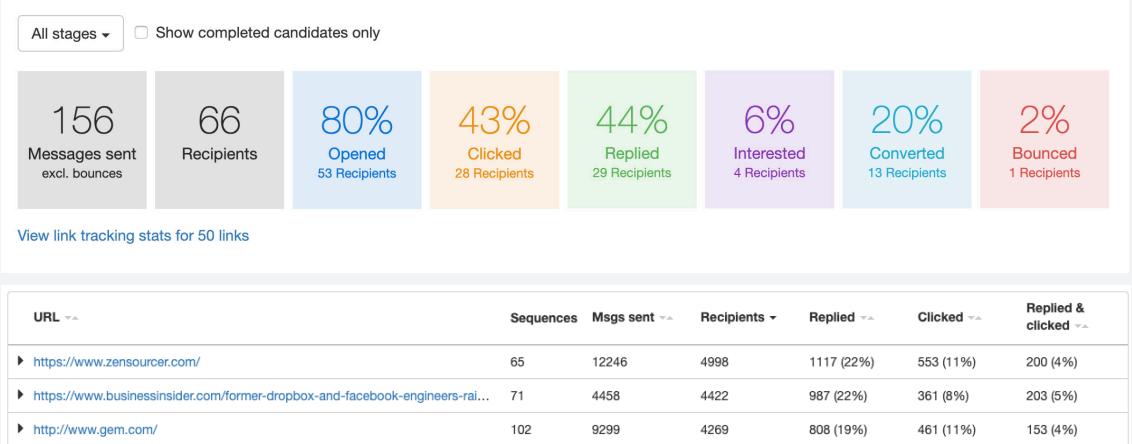
Hey {{first_name}},

Happy {{day_of_week}}! {{reason}}

Saw we have a bunch of mutual connections and that you've spent some time at {{company}} – was wondering if you've been thinking at all about what's next?

Message Copy: Content Stats

Gem's Content Stats allow you to add links to your outreach and track a candidate's engagement with those links over time. Content Stats tell you the number of times prospects click on a particular URL, the rate at which prospects reply after clicking on the URL, and more. Uncover insights into what content is most compelling to passive talent and how your talent brand is being received with your audiences so you can compose your outreach accordingly.



URL	Sequences	Msgs sent	Recipients	Replied	Clicked	Replied & clicked
https://www.zensourcer.com/	65	12246	4998	1117 (22%)	553 (11%)	200 (4%)
https://www.businessinsider.com/former-dropbox-and-facebook-engineers-rai...	71	4458	4422	987 (22%)	361 (8%)	203 (5%)
http://www.gem.com/	102	9299	4269	808 (19%)	461 (11%)	153 (4%)

Best Practices

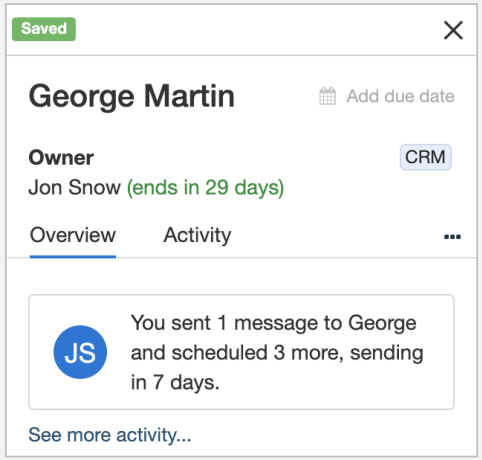
Codify Your Rules of Engagement

By defining when a recruiter can reach out to a given prospect (e.g. not for 30 days after another teammate has reached out), rules of engagement ensure recruiters aren't stepping on each other's toes—and that the talent team doesn't give the impression of being disorganized or out-of-sync with each other. Getting an email about the same job from multiple recruiters in a company is one of the biggest frustrations for talent. Rules of engagement ensure you don't damage your talent brand.

How Gem Helps

ROEs: Customized Ownership

Gem's activity overview provides visibility on ownership for every candidate profile. It shows whether anyone on your team has engaged with the prospect in some way (viewed their LinkedIn profile, added them to a Gem project, sent them a sequence, etc.), as well as who the current owner is—if there *is* one.



Vary Your Senders

At Gem, we recommend that recruiters send on behalf of their hiring managers or executives to reach highly sought-after talent (leadership, diversity prospects, etc). Our strongest users already make this a best practice. Wiith Gem, you can even send-on-behalf-of multiple teammates in the same sequence. Stages 1 and 2 might come from the recruiter; stage 3 from the hiring manager; and stage 4 from the Director of Engineering. *Now* you've got a high-touch engagement strategy from multiple people. Our customers have doubled their response rates with this strategy.

Varied Senders: SOBO

Gem allows you to send on behalf of (SOBO) others, like hiring managers or executives, in two ways. One uses email aliases, which allow the recruiter to maintain full control of the outreach and field any replies from the prospect. The other grants the recruiter access to the hiring manager's own email *only* to send the sequences; any replies from prospects go directly back to the hiring manager.

Best Practice

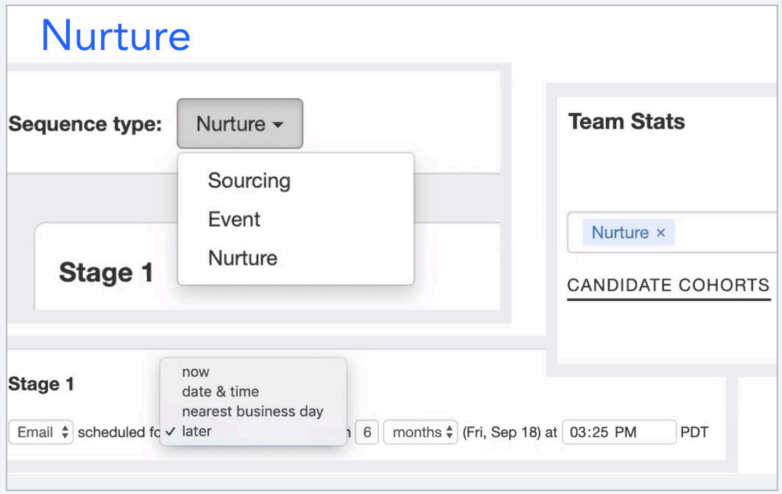
Long-Term Nurture

It can take between 12 and 20 touchpoints to influence a career decision. But by the time your initial outreach sequence ends, you've only had around 4 touchpoints with talent in a very specific 2-to-4-week window of their lives. Around 68% of them won't have responded. If recruiters don't pick up the thread for that 5th, 6th, and 7th touchpoint to maintain relationships with prospective candidates, they're starting from scratch every time a new role opens. This isn't an effective way of working. If your first outreach doesn't catch talent precisely when they're ready to make a move, that doesn't mean they won't be ready 4, 6, or 9 months down the line. Remember: 90% of passive talent say they could be tempted to move into a new role if the timing was right and the right opportunity came along. Nurture exponentially increases your chances of catching passive talent when the time is right.

How Gem Helps

Maintaining Long-Term Relationships with Prospects: Our Nurture Feature

Gem's Nurture feature lets recruiters easily set up a re-engagement sequence to go out in the future as soon as their initial outreach sequence ends. Whether recruiters see that 42% of talent opened an email in their initial sequence but never responded, or a candidate responds with a "not now; maybe later," recruiters can create and personalize nurture sequences for those segments and schedule them to go out in the future—at a specific date and time ("July 17th at 7:35 AM"), or with a relative later time period ("in 6 months"). Relative later dates are automatically forwarded to the next working day, and the nurture sequence can be threaded with the initial email sequence to make the conversation, over time, appear seamless.



Gem

Lauren Shufran, Author

Lauren is a content strategist with a penchant for 16th-century literature. When she's not trying to tap into talent teams' pain points, she's on her yoga mat or hiking the hills of Marin County. Come at her with your favorite Shakespeare quote.

Gem is an all-in-one recruiting platform that integrates with LinkedIn, email, and your Applicant Tracking System (ATS). We enable data-driven, world-class recruiting teams to find, engage, and nurture top talent. With Gem, recruiting teams can manage candidate pipeline with predictability.

To learn more and see a demo, visit

gem.com

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